



– none of them let you choose the type of panel you can have on your notebook. As a result, viewing angles of almost all laptops are nearly the same – give or take a few degrees. IPS panel displays are obviously expensive, given their superior quality compared to TN panels.

Another thing to consider while deciding between a 14-inch or 15.6-inch laptop is this: larger a laptop's screen, larger is its overall weight. So pick wisely.

Graphics

Generally, you choose a laptop that has your desired GPU inside, not the other way round. While changing RAM within a laptop is feasible, doing the same with GPUs is another matter altogether.

If you aren't going to game on your laptop and are content with watching regular DVD movies, then the onboard graphics should be enough to cater to your needs. Casual gaming and HD video content opens the door for a discrete graphics card. If you're buying a budget laptop with discrete graphics, we recommend looking at laptops with older generation hardware – NVIDIA GeForce GT 800M and AMD Radeon HD 8000M series graphics equipped laptops are still available in the market, so you should be able to find a really good bargain in an electronics store or on eBay.

Multimedia and gaming enthusiasts looking to max out their credit limit should look at the latest AMD Radeon HD 8000 / R7 2xx or R9 2xx and NVIDIA GeForce GT 800 / 900M graphics series, for gaming with latest generation DirectX 11 games on your laptop's native resolution.

Battery

A laptop's battery life is a matter of personal preference and intended usage – which may vary significantly from person to person. On average, a mainstream laptop with a six-cell battery will last for up to 3-4 hours on a single charge – laptops powered with ULVs or Ultra Low Voltage processors last longer, and netbooks last longest. If you don't expect to go mobile often and intend to use your laptop largely at home, don't bother with a bigger battery and stick with the standard battery bundled with the laptop.

If you'll be taking your machine on the road regularly, start looking at higher-capacity batteries for the next long haul. And don't trust vendors' battery life specs – many of them quote times for their laptops configured with higher-capacity

batteries and with many of the notebook's features turned off (dimming the screen brightness to nothingness and shutting off Wi-Fi, for instance).

Also, realise that a laptop configured with a quad-core Core i7 processor, several gigabytes of fast RAM, dedicated graphics and fast-spinning hard drive is going to eat up its battery at a considerably faster pace compared to, say, a netbook which has a single-core low-powered Atom processor, single GB of RAM and a slow-spinning hard drive. Most modern mainstream laptops these days come with automatic graphics switching built-in – NVIDIA GPUs have Optimus, while AMD GPUs have a toggle switch built into Catalyst Control Center.

But as a rule, you forgo on battery life the minute you start climbing higher up the performance ladder – be it laptops, mobile phones or any other battery-powered gadget.

Keyboard and trackpad

The keyboard and trackpad are also subjective features. However, there are a few ground rules in distinguishing and selecting a laptop with a good quality keyboard and trackpad.

Almost every laptop sold these days sports a keyboard with chiclet-styled, isolated keys. Even among them, a keyboard with curved key design is better for typing compared to flat-top chiclet-keys, simply due to the better ergonomics. Look for keyboards that don't short-change the sizes of important keys like alphabets, [Shift], [Space], [Alt], [Enter], [Tab], [Control] and direction keys. It's difficult to find a dedicated number pad on a 13 or 14-inch laptop, so if you'll be doing a lot of number-crunching on your laptop, opt for one that has a dedicated number pad.

Trackpads are easy to spot. Generally, stay away from trackpads that have a glossy, shiny surface (like the screen cover of a laptop). It makes tracking difficult and doesn't provide optimum feedback to the finger when you move it around on the trackpad. Choose a trackpad with a textured finish, it's generally the best for mouse tracking. Also, make sure that the mouse buttons below the trackpad are separate and well-built. Single-strip mouse buttons can be uncomfortable to use. 

